

ASIA



STRETCHING from the frozen Arctic to the equator, Asia is the world's largest continent. It is also a continent of extremes, containing the world's highest point, Mount Everest, as well as its lowest, the Dead Sea. China has the world's greatest population, while Asia's largest country, the Russian Federation, extends into Europe. Asia is separated from North America by the Bering Sea, and from Europe by the Caspian Sea, Turkey, and the Ural Mountains. In the southeast, it breaks into a mass of tiny islands.



Lake Baikal

Siberia, the northern region of Asia, has the oldest, deepest, and eighth largest lake in the world. Lake Baikal, which contains more than 20 per cent of the world's unfrozen fresh water, reaches a depth of 1,637 m (5,371 ft). It covers a total area of 31,468 sq km (12,150 sq miles).



Himalayas

The snow-capped Himalayan Mountains, the highest range in the world, form a massive natural barrier between the Indian subcontinent and northern Asia. They were pushed up millions of years ago when the Indian plate collided with the Eurasian plate.

ASIA FACTS

AREA	44,680,718 sq km (17,251,315 sq miles)
POPULATION	3,700,700,000
NUMBER OF COUNTRIES	49
BIGGEST COUNTRY	Russian Federation
SMALLEST COUNTRY	Maldives
HIGHEST POINT	Mt. Everest (China/Nepal) 8,848 m (29,029 ft)
LOWEST POINT	Dead Sea shore (Israel) 400 m (1,312 ft) below sea-level
LONGEST RIVER	Yangtze (Chang Jiang) (China) 6,380 km (3,965 miles)
BIGGEST LAKE	Caspian Sea 378,400 sq km (146,100 sq miles)

Cross-section through Asia

From the Indian Ocean, the land rises to the Vindhya Range in central India descending to the Ganges Plain, watered by the Himalayas. In the east, the mountains drop to the Great Plain of China. Across the Yellow Sea, the Korean Peninsula juts out near to Japan in the Pacific Ocean.

